

Excerpt from Chapter 4: Facilitating Discussion

from *Leading Others*

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The Question Development Dial

As we've seen, we spark curiosity by asking a question that a person knows something about but needs to think carefully to answer. It's about pushing just beyond the known into the unknown. We can use this principle to chain questions together to lead people to go deeper one step at a time. Arranging questions progressively is an important part of facilitating a good discussion.

One of my favorite tools to use to think up good questions and put them in a helpful order is the Question Development Dial. The dial is like a door handle that you grasp and turn to open up people's best thinking.

The handle part consists of words you might begin your question with—these help you to brainstorm questions. But the dial part is especially important for ordering questions in a good progression for discussion. It consists of three levels of thinking, each with three kinds of questions. By moving gradually from level 1 to level 2 to level



3, you can stimulate great discussion that brings up great insights.

Here are example questions to illustrate the different types. The first question of each pair could be used in a Bible study on James 3:13–18.⁴ The second question could be used in a worship team's discussion about introducing new songs in worship.

Level 1

The purpose of level 1 questions is to stir people's thinking around a specific topic. These questions surface initial thoughts, current wisdom, past experiences, and feelings.

Observation asks what people see so they might gain greater information or understanding.

- Which attitudes does James say are the key markers of bad wisdom?
- When we have introduced new songs in the past, how long is it until people seem comfortable with them?

Insight asks people what they might already know about the subject.

- In your experience, what are the key ingredients that go into making peace?
- How do you tell that the time is right to introduce a new song?

Opinion asks people what they personally think or feel about a subject.

- In your opinion, why do some smart people bring peace wherever they go while others who are just as smart bring strife?
- How often do you think new songs should be introduced to strike a balance between familiarity and variety?

Level 2

The purpose of level 2 questions is to help people think on a deeper, more analytical level. These questions help people evaluate, break down, segment, and verbalize concepts in their own words.

Evaluation asks people to assess the significance, worth, or quality of an item or experience.

- Think of the last time you observed (or participated in) an informal debate. How much did the debaters exhibit the characteristics of earthly wisdom versus the wisdom “from above”?

- The last time we introduced a song, how well did we help people pick it up (on a scale of 1 to 5)?

Analysis asks people to dissect various aspects of the topic for the purpose of understanding a process or design.

- According to James 3:18, how are righteousness and peace related to each other?
- Whom have you seen do a really good job introducing new songs, and what can we learn from their technique?

Descriptive asks people to describe something in their own words or to illustrate a concept.

- What true-to-life examples could we use to present the contrast between earthly wisdom and wisdom from above?
- What does a person need from us to sing along with a song they don't know yet?

Level 3

The purpose of level 3 questions is to challenge people to put what they are discussing into practice and move them to the level of transformational thinking.

Design asks people to consider how they would design, build, or lay out something.

- Imagine that someone you're working or serving with failed to come through and left you scrambling to pick up the pieces. What response fits the characteristics of wisdom from above?
- How would you structure this song's "road map" to make it easy

for people to learn the first time?

✕ **Transference** asks people to consider how they would communicate or transfer the concepts or lessons they learned to someone else.

- ✓ How would you describe the difference between bad wisdom and good wisdom to a pair of quarreling siblings, ages twelve and ten?
- What is the most important lesson about introducing new music that you would tell a person just starting out as a worship leader?

Application asks people how they will make specific application of the concepts they're learning.

- How will you install peaceable wisdom in a relationship where you're tempted by jealous, ambitious wisdom?
- What are three "best practices" we should follow when we introduce this song next weekend?

Explain in your own words how level 1 questions set up the thinking required for level 2 and how level 2 sets up level 3.

Level 1 - gets you familiar with the topic
and starts exploring thoughts +
feelings

Level 2 - thinking deeper about the
topic, drawing connections,
discovering new things

Level 3 - application, teaching it to
someone else

Asking Well

So far we've looked at why questions are important for facilitating a discussion that changes the people who take part. We've also explored different kinds of questions that we can use to take people progressively deeper into transformation. But without knowing more about how to engage people with our questions, we won't get the discussion we hope for. So here are five best practices for using questions to facilitate discussion.

1. Ask Simply

For a discussion to begin, someone has to go first in answering a question. But for someone to answer a question, they have to understand it. And in order to understand it, the question has to be simple enough to stick firmly when it is spoken.

"Simple" means a few things. First, the question should have the shortest words possible. Second, it should have the fewest words possible. (Note: These two rules often conflict with each other, so use good judgment.) It usually should also have the fewest clauses possible. So you don't want to say, "[1] What would you do [2] that fits the qualifications [3] that we listed [4] in order to accomplish our goal?" Instead you could ask this simply worded, one-clause question: "What approach might fit our list?"

Asking simply also means not asking two questions at once. Yes, there are exceptions to this, especially when the first question is to jog someone's memory and the second asks them about the thing they remember ("Who had the biggest impact on you, and what did they teach you?"). But in general, asking compound questions confuses people and leads to no answer or poor-quality answers. Beware of jamming two ideas into a single question too ("Where did you see the best example and the worst example?").

Finally, ask the question and then close your mouth! Don't continue on by rephrasing the same question in different words. Don't repeat the question. Don't answer your own question. Don't conclude with, "So, uh, what do any of you think?" Simply say the question in one breath and let it stand on its own in silence until someone answers or asks for clarification.

2. Ask Genuinely

To facilitate discussion, do not ask a question if you don't honestly want to know whatever people are thinking. I don't mean that you would be sneaky or dishonest in how you ask questions. Instead I mean that we're all tempted to use questions to steer the conversation in the direction we want it to go.

When we're standing in front of a class, we might ask a question looking for a particular "right" answer and nobody minds. That's because we're not really trying to facilitate discussion but convey information in an engaging way; that's what everyone expects us to do. But in a true discussion, leading questions are conversation killers. They turn a discussion into a lecture; either no one will respond or someone will answer and then silently wait for you to continue.

There's a difference between arranging questions for progressive depth and styling them to elicit particular answers. You can check yourself by considering whether your question assumes that the person you're asking agrees with you ("How can we get more of this thing that all of us like?") or whether you are looking for confirmation of your opinion ("Don't you think that . . . ?"). Be careful—often leading questions are phrased in a much more subtle way than these examples.

Most importantly, by taking on the role of facilitator, you are

giving up the role of ordinary participant. One of the rights you're giving up is the right to debate, maybe even the right to express disagreement unless a lively discussion on a topic has been rolling for some time. If a person says something you disagree with, let the rest of the group respond to it.

ASK - What do you think about what he said?

3. Ask Thoughtfully

Ask questions that don't have immediately obvious answers. If you ask a group of eager second-graders an obvious question, everyone will answer. If you ask any other group, no one will answer.

It is true that there is a place for relatively simple (but not too simple) observation questions near the beginning of a discussion ("What instructions does Jesus give the disciples in these verses?"). These get the whole group to focus their attention on stuff that is important for the topic being discussed.

But move as soon as possible to questions that require reflection, analysis, evaluation, or imagination. When people start to answer questions like that, it triggers new thoughts in the other people in the group, and they respond as well. Pretty soon you have a crackling discussion going.

4. Ask Patiently

When you ask a question simply, genuinely, and thoughtfully, you are well on your way to a great discussion. Do you know what comes next in a great discussion?

Silence.

Yes, that's right. Unless you're surrounded by electric extroverts (and sometimes even then), a really good question will make the room go quiet, because people are thinking about it. That's a good thing! Let the room breathe. Remember, you've already had the

question in your mind for a while; they're hearing it for the first time.

If the silence continues, ride it out until it gets uncomfortable. Then ride it out some more. Don't rush in to save them. The truth is that you probably feel more uncomfortable than the rest of the room does, so don't interrupt their thinking to save yourself!

5. Ask Ready

After the pregnant silence, someone will answer your terrific question. Great! But now what do you do?

Unless someone darts in to respond to the person before you do (which is usually a good thing!), respond by rephrasing back to them what they said. This shows that they've been heard and it may lead them to elaborate or go deeper all by itself.

Then you have a couple of options. One is to throw it back to the group by asking the question again. The other is to draw more out of the first answerer with a follow-up question. There are five kinds of follow-up questions that are good to have in your tool belt:



- Ask for **story**. ("When have you experienced that yourself?" "Who have you seen do that well?")
- Ask for **viewpoint**. ("How did you come to look at things that way?" "What would you change about this situation?")
- Ask for **diagnosis**. ("How would you rate yourself in that on a scale of 1 to 5?" "What would you do differently next time?")
- Ask for **steps**. ("What are the most important steps you can take over the next ninety days?" "If you could have someone to help you, who would it be?")
- Ask for **ideas**. This is asked to the whole group. ("What are four mistakes that people commonly make?" "What are three excuses people commonly give?")